

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHAT

FOR WHY-HOW · HOW-WHY

Milestone Backplanning

A template that converts a deep understanding of the work into dated milestones, built backward from the end. **The system view becomes a schedule.**

THE DRAIN

WHY-HOW and HOW-WHY profiles hold rich maps of what the work involves, but converting the map into a dated sequence of visible checkpoints is momentum work, and it drains. Without it, others see no schedule, and deep progress reads as no progress.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

Backplanning starts from the one date that is fixed, the end, and works in reverse, which suits a systems view far better than forward planning does. Each step back asks only: what must be true just before this? The output is a milestone chain others can see and steer by.

The backplan

- | | | |
|---|---------------------------|--|
| 1 | Fix the end state | The deliverable and its date, in one line at the right edge of the page. |
| 2 | Step backward | What must be true immediately before that? And before that? |
| 3 | Space the milestones | One visible checkpoint every two to four weeks. Visibility is the point. |
| 4 | Bring the first one close | The first milestone lands within ten days. Momentum starts now, not later. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Plan in one sitting, backward only.** Forward planning invites depth-first descent into detail. Backward stays at altitude.
- 2 **Make each milestone demonstrable.** Something you could show, not something you would explain.
- 3 **Publish the chain.** The milestones are for others as much as for you. Post them where the work lives.
- 4 **Re-plan only at milestones.** Between checkpoints, execute. The plan changes at the checkpoints, on purpose.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

A backplan is deliberately shallow; it is not the task-level plan, and it should not become one. Its job is visible pace. If milestones keep sliding, the finding is usually scope, not discipline, take that to the Good-Enough Threshold.

IN THE KIT

Backplanning template

Milestone spacing guide

Wall-format chain (print)

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 11 Good-Enough Threshold · **Tool 17** The Momentum Board · **Tool 8** Effort Reality-Check